

Chapter 116_1 - Kiss

Having spoken these words, she watched the woman's eyes widen, watched fury surge in those misty, rain-like eyes, then heard the whoosh of wind as Ning Fuyi smoothly tilted her face to one side.

A stinging sensation floated on the surface without breaking the skin. Ning Fuyi's eyelashes trembled as her fingertips touched her cheek.

The skin retained a faint sensation - traces of being scratched by fingernails. Chu Qingqiu's slap must have used all her strength, but when it landed on her face, it stopped abruptly.

She turned her head back to see the woman's pale face covered in moisture, the lamplight illuminating her tears like stars and moon, dimming as she turned her head.

"You've gone too far." Chu Qingqiu's voice was broken and intermittent. She covered her eyes with her arm, her shoulders trembling.

Ning Fuyi was silent for a long while, looking up at the underground palace ceiling scattered with fluorescent light. Only when those points of light were no longer blurred by moisture did she speak again: "Why did you come tonight?"

"Don't give me those high-sounding reasons. I don't believe them." She shook her head. "You clearly remember the mortal realm affairs, yet you never came looking for me."

"Do you want to do the same as thirty years ago - never mention what you've done, leaving me alone to guess wildly? You denied dual cultivating¹ with me, desperately pushing me away. Now do you want to erase the memories of being Su Mo as well?"

"I haven't hidden very deeply. If you just asked Jiang Li, she would immediately tell you where I am! I wait for you every day, but you just won't come. Chu Qingqiu, what kind of terrible monster am I that you avoid me so desperately?"

"You remember, don't you? Everything from the mortal realm?" Ning Fuyi spoke, reaching out to grasp Chu Qingqiu's arm and forcefully pulling her back in front of herself.

The woman's breathing was rapid, her eyes closed without speaking.

"Whether I indulge in sensual pleasures or have many Du Baishuang by my side - if you had no special feelings for me, why would you be so angry?"

As Ning Fuyi spoke, she stepped forward, watching Chu Qingqiu slowly retreat until her back pressed against the door. Her slender neck extended in delicate lines, tilting to one side.

"My delusions about you, my obsessions - they're so obvious you couldn't possibly not know. So why exactly? Why do you push me away? Why do you clearly care about me yet remain silent?"

Ning Fuyi felt she was going mad. She wished she could use every method to pry open the woman's mouth - whether pleasant or unpleasant, she just wanted to hear what she was really thinking.

"When you died, you couldn't see how desperate I was. You pulled me out of the mire, then kicked me back in with one foot. You didn't even speak before trading your life - yes, you're a Divine Venerable, you have the world in your eyes, but I don't. In my eyes, there's only you."

Ning Fuyi sniffled. By now she was extremely close to Chu Qingqiu. Her fingertips gripped the woman's smooth arms, slowly sliding to her wrists, grasping firmly and pressing them against the door.

The fragrance from Chu Qingqiu's body seemed to be saturated by tears, becoming even richer and more intoxicating, making one's head swim.

Ning Fuyi lowered her head to smell her neck, causing the woman to tremble. Chu Qingqiu's spine pressed tightly against the cold iron door, leaving half her beautiful profile visible. Her whole body was shaking - whether from anger or resistance was unclear.

Her resistance cooled the fiery excitement in Ning Fuyi's heart, quickly sinking it into the depths of her heart.

Ning Fuyi raised her head and released her.

With a red nose tip, she smiled sarcastically and spoke: "See, it's like this again."

She pulled a cotton-linen handkerchief from her sleeve and stuffed it into Chu Qingqiu's hands, pretending nonchalance: "Wipe yourself. If you're tired, you can rest a while before leaving."

Having said this, she pulled Chu Qingqiu aside with her left hand and the iron door with her right, about to leave. But suddenly she felt a tugging sensation on her sleeve, causing her heart to leap as she slowly looked down.

Moon-white fingertips clutched her sleeve, like pearls fallen onto black fabric.

"Are you going to find Du Baishuang?" Chu Qingqiu spoke, her voice carrying the nasal tone of someone who had been crying, making her sound less ethereally immortal.

Ning Fuyi didn't say yes or no, only saying: "Since you don't want me, why do you care who I seek?"

Chu Qingqiu spoke, her gaze sweeping over the romantic atmosphere in the hall: "She's such a beauty, naturally lovable."

"Pretty appearance, gentle nature - quite endearing indeed." Ning Fuyi's words were half-true, half-false.

She stepped toward the door again, but the fingertips clutching her sleeve didn't loosen - instead, they gripped tighter.

"Come back." Chu Qingqiu lowered her head, her voice weary.

Ning Fuyi then stepped back into the hall. At the same time, the great door closed, and the room fell silent again. Incense continued burning faintly, but couldn't overcome the floral fragrance nearby.

She looked at Chu Qingqiu. Lamplight lingered on her shoulders - the woman was so beautiful she didn't seem real. She closed her eyes and said: "I'll do it."

Ning Fuyi's throat moved.

"You know now, don't you? I'm also of the spirit clan." Chu Qingqiu raised her eyes, peach blossom eyes misty with vapor, unfathomably deep.

Her usually cold and aloof expression was made somewhat fragile by the flowing lamplight. Ning Fuyi's gaze darkened, her pupils equally deep against the backlight.

"Mm."

Having spoken, Ning Fuyi suddenly lowered her head to kiss Chu Qingqiu, trapping those longed-for lips between her own to bite and press. Thirty years of resentment now transformed entirely into possessive madness. The endless gardenia fragrance was swallowed into her belly, and electric currents spread along her spine.

She felt the urge to cry again.

Chu Qingqiu hadn't expected Ning Fuyi to be so relentless. Her body involuntarily fell backward, but was caught by the woman's hand on her waist, steadying her stumbling form.

Intense suffocation quickly enveloped her, causing her to pant lightly as her hands climbed up Ning Fuyi's lapels, gripping tightly.

This feeling had never existed in the mortal realm. Back then, Ning Fuyi was always gentle, not even daring to embrace with force. But now those lips seemed to want to absorb all the breath from her body. Chu Qingqiu's vision quickly began to darken.

She immediately collapsed softly, her lips brushing past Ning Fuyi's earlobe as she stumbled into her embrace, then forcefully closed her eyes and leaned against her shoulder, silently weeping.

Holding the cool body in her arms, Ning Fuyi felt somewhat dazed. One hand stroked her hair, gently caressing along the grain of her tresses as if comforting.

Then she glanced behind her and suddenly flew up with Chu Qingqiu. The two landed on the swing, and as it began to sway, Ning Fuyi once again found those lips that had turned red as blood.

This time she was even more merciless, easily prying apart pearl-like teeth and hearing soft muffled sounds from the woman curled up on the swing.

Chu Qingqiu didn't resist, but closed her eyes like a light boat drifting with the current, enduring the turbulent waves crashing down.

She was almost completely sinking into the woman's embrace, her lips numb with pain, but the cold that had followed her for days completely disappeared. Instead, she was covered in warmth throughout her body, so hot that clear sweat nearly trickled down her spine.

After an unknown time - long enough that both could barely breathe - Ning Fuyi finally stopped tormenting her. She released her shoulders and looked down at those lips that had become almost transparent red.

Chu Qingqiu's eyes uncontrollably filled with tears. Her mouth closed slightly, then she pressed her lips together and turned to one side, not looking at Ning Fuyi's face.

Ning Fuyi suddenly wanted to laugh, but before the corners of her mouth could rise, tears fell first. She closed her eyes and shook her head.

Over these years, her heart had grown harder while her eyes had become softer. Not to mention one pot of gardenia flowers - even raising several more pots probably wouldn't be a problem.

"Aren't you supposed to advance your cultivation? Why did you stop?" Chu Qingqiu said coldly. When she spoke, she didn't look at Ning Fuyi - whether from embarrassment or fear of exposing the emotions in her eyes.

"You mean dual cultivating with spirit clan members, absorbing their essence?" Ning Fuyi spoke, reaching out to touch Chu Qingqiu's eye corner, wiping away all the tears that had fallen during their kiss.

She smiled: "I was lying to you."

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu raised her hand to summon her white bone weapon, but the woman stared fixedly at her, and the white bone flying in mid-air clattered to the ground again.

Ning Fuyi's gaze made her somewhat tense - there were too many emotions in those phoenix eyes, difficult to decipher.

Yes, that girl who used to be so easy to understand had now become completely inscrutable. Chu Qingqiu felt somewhat dazed.

"Chu Qingqiu, I just want you to say one thing - do you have feelings for me in your heart or not?" She spoke word by word.

Chu Qingqiu's mouth opened but no sound came out.

"Hall Master!" Just then, the great door was suddenly pounded on. The soul-stirring atmosphere immediately vanished, and both were disturbed by the door-pounding sounds.

Ning Fuyi could bear it no longer and sat up, shouting sternly: "What is it? Report it later!"

"Oh..." Han Ya outside the door walked back a few steps, then returned to knock: "But Hall Master, this is extremely important!"

"I don't care how important it is - I also have urgent matters at hand. Leave immediately!" Ning Fuyi's fire burned to the top of her head.

"Oh..." Han Ya turned again, thought for a moment, then returned, saying pitifully: "But Hall Master, this matter is really, extremely important..."

Ning Fuyi raised her hand to find her spike weapon to stab her, but Chu Qingqiu caught her wrist. The desire that had filled her eyes moments before had vanished, replaced by her usual composure.

Seeing her expression, Ning Fuyi knew what she would say, so she brushed her sleeves and stood up: "Then I'll go first. No one in this Chuwei Hall will stop you - Divine Venerable, please do as you wish."

Having said this, she flashed to the door and opened it. After hearing a crow's cry, the two had already departed.

Chu Qingqiu paused, then collapsed powerlessly, her hand gripping the lapels at her chest until her fingertips turned white.

Footnotes

¹ **Dual cultivation (双修)** - A cultivation practice where two people cultivate together, sharing and enhancing each other's spiritual energy. Can be platonic or intimate depending on the method.